existent on these temple walls, such as pregnant women, women giving birth or women with babies.)

The earliest sculptures of *copulating* couples appeared on religious monuments in mid-first millennium CE. Though initially small and discreetly placed, they appeared on temples across India, including in Mathura, Gujarat, Mysore, Ajanta, Ellora, Badami, Aihole, Pattadakal, Bhubaneshwar and many other sites. But the size, finesse and centrality of erotic art on temple walls kept growing until it became a wider artistic convention that, not surprisingly, paralleled the rise of Tantrism. All across India after the mid-first millennium, writes Thapar, 'articulation of the erotic is evident in poetry and temple sculpture, perhaps released by the rituals and ideas current in Tantric belief and practice which were being assimilated among the elite.' Representations of these erotic themes are 'striking, whether in the *Gita Govinda* or in the sculptures at Khajuraho'.[24]

According to Desai, the first-known cunnilingus scene on temple art appeared in Aihole in the sixth century; the first bestiality scene in Bhubaneshwar in the eighth century; the first orgiastic scene in Pattadakal in the eighth century. What's striking about Khajuraho's erotic temple art is therefore not the uniqueness of any one of its depictions but their impressive range, number and size, as well as their sensual boldness, artistic finesse, thematic diversity and visual prominence on both outside walls *and* the walls of inner sanctums, the *garbhagriha*. But how did Tantrism impact such depictions of the erotic on temple walls?

To understand what all this explicit sex on temples meant to their creators, we must try and enter their world and imagine it from within. To do this, let's begin with three fairly simple and uncontroversial premises. *First*, the sponsors of explicit erotica on temple walls clearly saw it as compatible with depictions of the divine. *Second*, these temples were public monuments and places of worship, commissioned by the royals not to shock, outrage or confuse people but to communicate a stable vision of life and to acquire merit, fame and legitimacy. *Third*, since the temples were built over 250 years by multiple kings, this vision wasn't just driven by a small coterie of reformist royals—a revolutionary vanguard determined to broaden people's sexual horizons. Rather, it's safe to assume that the art was an expression of an aesthetic that was already common in the realm and